

SHELLFISH

The shells that you find on a beach are the empty homes of small animals called shellfish. These soft-bodied creatures need hard shells to protect them from starfish, crabs, fish, and birds.

The most common types of shellfish are gastropods and bivalves. Gastropods are underwater snails. They grow coiled shells and slide around on a slimy foot. Bivalves have two, flatter shells that cover their whole body.



Growing up

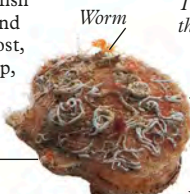
Unlike crabs, shellfish never shed their shells. Each baby, or larva, has a tiny shell that gets bigger as it grows.

Because their shells are so light, bubble shells can use their mantles as flippers to help them swim.



The animal inside

Bivalves, gastropods, and all other shellfish have soft bodies and no backbones. Most, such as this scallop, have shells.



These feelers help the animal find food.

Water in

Water out

Eye

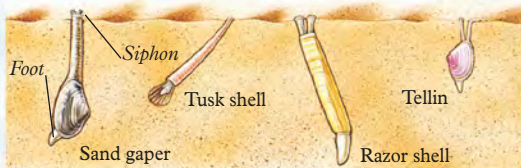


Swimming scallops

By taking in water and then shooting it out of its back end, a scallop is able to jump through the sea.

Buried alive

Tusk shells and many bivalves spend most of their life buried in sand. Bivalves dig a hole with their foot, then poke tubes, or siphons, into the sea. The siphons take water into the bivalve's gills and catch food.



Eye on a stalk